Northeast also supplied one part of an old jigsaw puzzle. Khasi, in Meghalaya, was clearly Austro-Asiatic—unlike its neighbours—and thus part of a family that mostly stays in *another* part of India. This is the canonical 'Adivasi' group: Munda, Santhal, Kol, Ho et al, strung around the contiguous tribal districts of Jharkhand, Bengal and Odisha. There was another outlier: Nicobarese. (The Andamanese groups speak entirely unrelated languages.) Outside India, the biggest representatives of Austro-Asiatic are found on the far side of Indochina—Vietnamese and Cambodia's Khmer—and some on the Malay coast. Quite a disunited family, by geography. How did this come about?

There has never been a dearth of theories, including (inevitably!) an overland 'Out of India' one. But linguist Paul Sidwell, refining a model over years, has furnished us with a new, compelling one: the Munda Maritime Hypothesis. In this reading, the Urheimat—or original homeland—of proto-Austro-Asiatic was Vietnam's Red River delta, from where a Chinese influx drove them out in waves of migration. Primary route: the sea, through the Strait of Malacca, with a pit-stop at Nicobar, up to the Mahanadi Delta. Timeframe: circa 2000 BC, around the same time as the Vedic people up north. As with the latter, and most other ancient migrations, there was a gender skew: a small, predominantly male founder population mixing with local Ancient Ancestral South Indians. Both linguistics and genetics converge here. A separate, secondary dispersal—inland, up the tributaries of the Red River—deposited languages like Palaungic and Khmuic in Laos and Yunnan, with Khasi being the westernmost sibling. What all this does is dispel the common myth of an umbilical cord between 'people' and 'language'. Imagine a Mundari Eve, with a Dravidian matriarch and a seaweary father from out east. ■

What this does is dispel the myth of an umbilical cord tying people and language



rebellion of 1831. The great **Santhal Hul** of 1855 was the big one, overshadowed only by 1857. The names of its protagonists, **Sidu** and **Kanhu Murmu**, or that of a stray **Tantia Bhil** (left)—bandit to the British, but 'Robin Hood' to compatriots—and an iconic **Birsa Munda** remain the few we can write on a monument that's yet to be made. ■

A FEW 'GREAT LEADERS'

JAIPAL SINGH MUNDA



From a cattle-herding boyhood in Jharkhand's Khunti division to Oxford to captaining an Indian hockey team that won the Olympic Gold in 1928, to the Indian Civil Service, to presiding over the Adivasi Mahasabha and becoming the first prominent voice for a separate Jharkhand state, to membership of the Constituent Assembly, he was really 'Marang Gomke' (Great Leader).

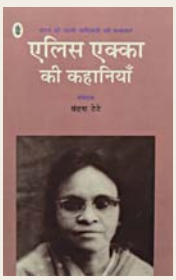
NANJIYAMMA



Musicologists have long speculated on the folk genesis of Indian classical music. But it took a song in the Irula language by Nanjiyamma for the film, *Ayyappanum Koshiyum* (2020), and a national award for best female playback singer to announce the arrival of a distinctive southern tribal vocalism on stage.

ALICE EKKA

To answer the question, 'Can the Subaltern write?'...well, yes.



A strikingly original voice, Ekka's Hindi stories—written mostly in the 1950s-60s, prefiguring even much of the Dalit resistance writings—are currently being rediscovered by local and western scholars. Leitmotif: strong female characters.